

Introduction: The Power of Team

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Did you grow up in a high-functioning team? Some people learn the power of teamwork through their high school sports. For some, the concept of team is new in the workforce. Still, others may have experienced the concept of team before, but a slightly dysfunctional one. Wherever you're starting from, the power of team in today's workforce isn't a skill that comes naturally. To say so much emphasis placed on honing individuals or subject matter expertise that qualities that become a world-class team often fade to the background.

Pat Summitt was no stranger to the importance of team, and she was a social engineer at building championship-level performing teams. That included individuals from all walks of life. Pat once said, "Team building starts by recruiting good people and turning them into willing role models early on."

How do you convince a group of highly talented individual performers to set aside their personal feelings, ambitions, and agendas in favor of a united effort? When I think about this and I think about Pat, I often think about what she thought was so important was people knowing their role. I remember one year we had three seniors on the team. All of them were great players. We had a freshman who was really better than the three seniors. And it came time to vote for All-American. Pat came in and said, "I need to vote for the freshman, but I hate to leave these two seniors who've had a great year off." And I said, "Let's talk about it." And she said, "I need to talk to them." So, she went in and she talked to them about why she was going to vote for the freshman and why the other two were such an important part of the team. Guess what? We went on into the championship. One of the seniors got the most valuable player at the SEC tournament. The next senior got the most valuable player at the regionals. And the freshman helped us win a national championship and was an All-American. That might not have happened if Pat didn't realize the importance of team and how it affected everybody else.

Communication and the roles that they play are so important. In this program, we'll identify some important characteristics for building a great team wherever you are. We'll take a closer look specifically at Pat's Definite Dozen of loyalty, responsibility, and communication, three of the core principles for forming a healthy, functioning group. At the end of each lesson, you'll be challenged to build on these principles with personal reflections and short exercises. At the end of each module, there is a short quiz to test what you've learned. At the end of this course, you'll know more about teamwork and the key components that can take your teams to the next level. Let's get started.